

— SPM 381 — CONSUMER BEHAVIOR IN SPORT

Social Media Issues in Sports

Current Controversies and Athlete Welfare Concerns

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Social Media: The New Center of the Fan Experience — and a New Risk Surface

Social media has become central to how fans consume sport — building on our earlier semester discussion of media consumption. But that same centrality has created new problems: disruption of live competition, athlete harassment, and the politicization of athletes' platforms.

- 01 — US Open Influencer Disruption: Content creators halt live play at the 2026 US Open.
- 02 — FIFA World Cup Online Abuse: ~89,000 abusive posts flagged in the group stage alone.
- 03 — Winter Olympics Political Backlash: US athletes targeted after political comments in Milan-Cortina.
- 04 — NCAA Harassment Survey: 51% of DI men's basketball players report abuse tied to performance.
- 05 — Quan Hongchan Cyberbullying: A global pattern of athlete-directed harassment campaigns.

Case Study — US Open, September 2026: When Content Creation Interrupts Competition

- *How should venues balance fan/creator content culture against the integrity of live competition?*
- During Naomi Osaka's first-round match at the 2026 US Open, a group of social media content creators set up ring lights and staged a photoshoot in the stands mid-play.
- The disruption forced the chair umpire to pause the match.
- The incident became a flashpoint for tension between fan/creator content culture and the integrity of live competition.

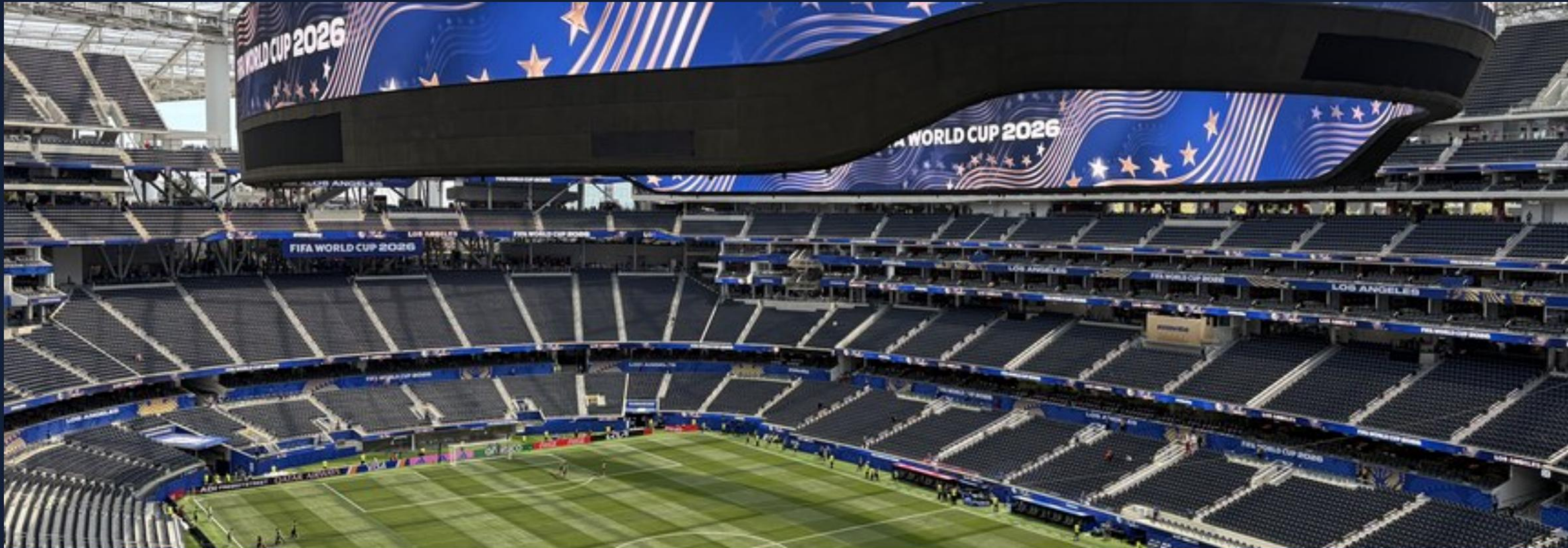
Source — youtube.com/watch?v=QL4X_662Yd0

The USTA's response frames the issue as a balance problem, not a ban — fan and creator access on one side, competitive integrity on the other.

*“We want our fans and guests to have an incredible time when they attend the US Open, but we also need to ensure that does not interfere with the action and competition on the court.” —
BRENDAN McINTYRE, USTA SPOKESPERSON*

Case Study — FIFA World Cup 2026: Abuse at Scale — The Group Stage Alone

- *What responsibility do platforms and governing bodies share for protecting athletes from abuse?*
- Flagged by FIFA's Social Media Protection Service during the group stage of the 2026 World Cup alone.
- Part of a documented rise in player-directed harassment tied to match outcomes and officiating decisions.



89,000

abusive posts identified during the group stage of the 2026 World Cup

Case Study — Winter Olympics, Milan-Cortina, February 2026: Speaking Out, Facing Backlash

- US athletes — freestyle skier Hunter Hess, aerialist Chris Lillis, and snowboarder Amber Glenn — faced coordinated online attacks after commenting on domestic politics while competing.
- Public figures including Jake Paul and Brett Favre publicly criticized them.



Source — [youtube.com/watch?v=1Jv0_IxWbM](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=1Jv0_IxWbM)

Glenn announced she would limit her social media use for her wellbeing.

Should athletes be expected to separate their personal political views from their public platform? What are the consequences either way?

*“a scary amount of hate / threats for simply using my voice
WHEN ASKED about how I feel” — AMBER GLENN*

Player-Welfare & Mental Health — and a Global Pattern

- Reported receiving social media abuse tied directly to their in-game performance, per an NCAA survey of Division I men's basketball student-athletes.
- A growing player-welfare and mental-health concern, prompting new platform-reporting and moderation tools from conferences.
- Quan Hongchan, a high-profile Chinese Olympic diver, was targeted in 2026 by coordinated online harassment campaigns — cited here as part of the wider global pattern of athlete-directed cyberbullying this year.



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Why This Matters for Sport Marketers and Managers

#	IMPLICATION
A	Athlete mental health and retention
B	Reputational risk to leagues/venues from viral incidents
C	Growing need for athlete social-media-safety policies and platform moderation partnerships
D	Tension between maximizing fan engagement/content culture and protecting competition integrity and athlete wellbeing

Wrap-Up Questions

What proactive steps can a team, league, or venue take to reduce these risks before they escalate into a crisis?

How should platforms and governing bodies share responsibility for protecting athletes from targeted abuse?

Where should the line sit between fan/creator engagement and protecting competition integrity and athlete wellbeing?

References

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- Sunday Guardian Live. "US Open 2026: Social Media Influencers Face Backlash For Chaotic Photo Session During Naomi Osaka Match."
- Sports.legal. "Beyond the Final Whistle at the FIFA World Cup: The Growing Crisis of Social Media Abuse in Professional Sport." July 2026.
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